

Chapter 156-3

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Xu Qingzhu was awakened by a nightmare again.

When she woke up, it should have been around 3:30 in the morning.

She had already woken up at this time for several nights now, then endured the long night alone.

Today seemed a bit better, because there was someone sleeping beside her. She carefully picked up her phone from the nightstand and found it was 4:00 AM.

Half an hour more sleep than before.

Perhaps because they had been more intense last night.

Liang Shi beside her was still sound asleep. Xu Qingzhu felt a dragging pain in her lower abdomen, the kind that pulled her whole body downward.

So she tiptoed to the bathroom.

It seemed her period had come early. There were bloodstains on her underwear.

She changed into fresh underwear and put on a new sanitary pad.

The pads in the cabinet should have been the ones left over from when Liang Shi last used them. There were only two left.

But there were quite a few panty liners.

The light in the bathroom was dim. She hadn't brought her phone, so she just sat on the toilet in a daze.

She raised her hand to wipe her forehead. The cold sweat from the nightmare had already evaporated. Her hand then rested on her forehead, supporting the weight of her upper body.

The pain in her lower abdomen was far less unbearable than the muddled feeling in her head.

It was like countless little people arguing in her mind. She couldn't hear what they were arguing about, but she could hear the chaotic noise.

To be more specific, it was like sleeping next to the Yujiang Bridge, with vehicles constantly passing over it, always able to hear the sound of tires rubbing against the ground.

Helpless. Powerless.

This had been Xu Qingzhu's frequent state lately.

Many times she simply didn't want to sleep anymore and would get up to work.

But there would always come a time when work was done, so she had bought a silent piano and placed it in Liang Shi's bedroom. When she couldn't sleep at night, she would try playing it—a way to pass the time.

But more often, she would sit blankly on the sofa all night until dawn.

She used to have a very regular schedule. In an era when young people were all trying to maintain nocturnal sleep schedules,¹ she was often teased by Sally and Lin Luoxi for not living like a young person at all.

She hadn't seen the 6 AM sun in many years; lately, she saw it every day.

Even sleeping had become something terrifying.

As soon as she thought about sleeping, she would start to resist.

She thought it was the bed's problem, so she moved the blanket and pillow to the sofa. Before sleeping, she would leave the TV on, find a relaxing slow-paced variety show or an old movie to watch, then continue sleeping.

But unexpectedly, there was still no improvement.

It was just easier to space out on the sofa.

So she lay on the sofa.

The most direct impact of poor sleep was mental fatigue. She looked completely drained of energy.

She was spacing out more and more during the day. Lin Luoxi even suspected she had been followed by some kind of monster, frequently being paranoid, and even suggested she find a shaman to take a look.²

Xu Qingzhu actually went. The fact proved that feudal superstition was not advisable.

That person wanted Xu Qingzhu to drink limewater, saying she was being followed by a fox spirit.

Lin Luoxi was dumbfounded at the time. Xu Qingzhu poured the limewater on the ground and drove back to the city to buy a hot milk tea.

These days had indeed been terrible.

But as long as she thought of Liang Shi, Xu Qingzhu felt it was okay.

She also knew she couldn't let Liang Shi know about these things. Based on Liang Shi's personality, if she knew, she would definitely feel guilty and blame herself.

So she had to act extra lively and push all her discomfort onto work.

Using work as a catch-all excuse could help Liang Shi avoid guilt.

Liang Shi probably knew something. This matter might also be related to Lu Jiayi.

But Liang Shi was unwilling to say or couldn't say, so Xu Qingzhu didn't ask.

Even if she asked, she wouldn't get an answer.

Either she would be deceived, or she would see Liang Shi in a difficult position.

She didn't want either, so she chose to suppress these things. After all, it wasn't a matter of life and death.

If Liang Shi hadn't appeared downstairs today, Xu Qingzhu would have already driven to the hospital to get sleeping pills. She had asked Zhao Xuning to prescribe some sleep aids.

But when she saw Liang Shi coming, she told Zhao Xuning she wouldn't go for now—she'd go tomorrow.

She thought it would be like last time, that she would be fine once Liang Shi came back, but she had only improved a little bit.

Xu Qingzhu sat in the bathroom sighing, rubbing her temples.

Only when the pain in her lower abdomen eased a bit did she get up.

She tiptoed back to the room again. Liang Shi wasn't sleeping soundly either and was awakened by the sound of the door. She was about to get up but was pressed back down by Xu Qingzhu.

Liang Shi reached out to turn on the bedside lamp, her voice hoarse: "Did you have another nightmare?"

"No." Xu Qingzhu got into bed, her body curling up in Liang Shi's embrace.

She had just washed her hands, which were even colder than before. When she placed her hands on Liang Shi's waist, Liang Shi was mostly awakened.

"My period came." Xu Qingzhu said. "My stomach hurts a little, so I went to the bathroom."

Liang Shi's hand fell on her lower abdomen and rubbed it gently. "I remember it wasn't at this time last month."

"Right, last month it was around the same time as yours." Xu Qingzhu said. "Maybe it's because of work stress lately. It came early."

"Alright." Liang Shi asked. "Do you want a hot water bottle?"

"No need." Xu Qingzhu moved closer to her. "Just warm me up."

In the later part of the night, the heating wasn't as warm. Stepping barefoot on the floor was actually quite cold.

Xu Qingzhu didn't want Liang Shi to get up either, so she placed her somewhat cold feet on Liang Shi's calves. "Mm."

Liang Shi asked what was wrong, and she nuzzled into Liang Shi's embrace: "Your arms are so warm."

Liang Shi laughed softly: "Your constitution is really weak. When I finish filming this drama..."

She suddenly stopped mid-sentence.

"What?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi pressed her lips together and said slowly: "I'll take you to the hospital to get checked out, or find a traditional Chinese medicine practitioner to help regulate your body."

Xu Qingzhu scoffed lightly. "These are really just old problems. The Chinese medicine doctor said there's nothing wrong with me."

Liang Shi: "I don't believe it unless she tells me in person."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

Footnotes:

1. "Nocturnal sleep schedules" (陰間作息): Literally "underworld schedule," this is Chinese internet slang for staying up extremely late and sleeping during the day, as if one's schedule belongs to ghosts or the dead rather than living people.
2. "Shaman" (跳大神的): Refers to folk practitioners who perform rituals involving trance-like states, often dancing or chanting, to communicate with spirits and cure ailments. This practice, while still found in some rural areas, is generally considered superstition in modern China.